This was no coincidence; it is now known that the Chinese were already aware of correspondence between the Government of India and the Dalai Lama's government in 1948 (before the founding of the People's Republic of China), wherein the Tibetan government had demanded that independent India should first return all the lands occupied by the British Empire. Sikkim was one of the territories claimed by them. [4] A cable from the Chinese Foreign Ministry to their ambassadors in July 1955, which contained several suggestions to strengthen ties with Afro-Asian nations, contained instructions to the effect that 'we should formulate a secret stipulation on the status of Sikkim, Bhutan, Kanjuti, etc.' [5] In 1954, the Chinese published a map showing Sikkim as a part of China. [6] These instances suggest that the new Communist government in Beijing wanted to keep all options open, including the Tibetan claims over Sikkim. Although they were in no position at that point of time to challenge India over Sikkim, Zhou Enlai shrewdly declined to engage in any activity that might suggest China's *de jure* recognition of Sikkim as a protectorate of India. For this reason, when India proposed that the boundary discussions should include the Sikkim–Tibet (China) sector, the Chinese Ministry of Foreign Affairs wrote to the Indian Embassy in Beijing on 26 December 1959, saying that 'the boundary between China and Sikkim has long been formally delimited and there is neither any discrepancy between the maps nor any disputes in practice.' [7] When Indian Ambassador Parathasarathi paid his farewell call on Vice Foreign Minister Geng Biao in Beijing on 19 July 1961, the Head of the Asian Department, Zhang Wenjin, who was also present, even alleged that India was wilfully trying to involve China in order to pressurize Sikkim (and Bhutan) into accepting India's version of where their boundaries with China lay. [8] In reality, the Chinese were buying time, and possibly studying records, while they made up their